



Bystander to Upstander

Behind-the-back laughing needs an audience, and most of that audience does not think it is involved. Students take one ordinary corridor moment, work out how many people were part of it, learn the five roles a group splits into, and write the words they would really use. It gets them noticing what they are part of, and gives them something to do about it.

Before you start. This one can land close to something already happening in your form, so do not use a real incident or a real name, and do not run it the day after one, because the student it happened to will know. Nothing students write is collected or read out, and the deck says so on slide 2. If something is disclosed during or after the lesson, follow it up outside the room in the usual way. The names in the script are made up: change any that match a student in your year group.

Print these

Page	What it is	How many
Page 2	The answer key, and the three studies	One, for you
Page 3	The sheet they write on	One per student
Page 4	Eight moment cards	One set, cut up

The hour

Time	What happens	Slides
4 min	In pairs, work out who was part of one ordinary moment. They keep the list.	3
3 min	Count it together. Most forms say two people. It is eight.	4
6 min	Name the thing they already recognise, then teach the five roles and where somebody counted them.	5 to 7
7 min	In pairs, predict what the playground study found, then reveal the two numbers and let them argue about whether it holds here.	8 to 9
7 min	Model one that works and one that backfires, then teach the three ways out.	10 to 11
3 min	Do one together, out loud, and put two answers on the board.	12
12 min	In pairs, write the actual words for two of the three, on the sheet.	13
6 min	Sheets move two tables along and get marked against the three questions.	14
5 min	Discuss whether not laughing is enough. There is no right answer.	15
4 min	Exit ticket, kept by the student.	16

Worth knowing

- The count on slide 4 is the lesson in one number. Let them argue about whether the two who were never there count, because working out why they do is the part that lands.
- If your form goes quiet on the discussion, lean on the marking round instead. Sheets moving two tables along gets more out of most groups than a question to the whole room.

Most of them will recognise their own role before the hour is over.





What to say, and what backfires

The one place in this lesson where you have to come up with something on the spot is the round you do together. These are the answers to have ready.

Words that work

What they say	Why it works
“That is not funny any more.”	Flat, not angry, then straight on to something else. It ends the audience without starting an argument.
“Leave it, we are going to be late.”	Gives the group a reason to move. Nobody has to admit anything, which is why it usually works.
“Did you finish that homework?”	A change of subject is an intervention. It does not have to be about the thing at all.

What sounds braver and does not work

What they say	What happens
“You are such a bully.”	Puts somebody on trial in front of the audience, and the audience is the problem. It gets defended, and the joke carries on later.
Laughing, then apologising afterwards.	The laugh is the part everybody saw.
Telling the person everything that was said.	It feels like honesty and lands as a second round of it.

The count on slide 4, if it is disputed

How many	Who
1	Theo. Said it once, at break.
3	The three who laughed at break. Without them it ends there.
1	Kai, who repeated it to a group that had not heard it.
2	The two saying it by Thursday who were never there.
1	Nadia, who stopped answering by Friday.

The three studies

Study	What it found
Salmivalli and others, 1996	Aggressive Behavior, 22, 1 to 15. 573 students aged twelve and thirteen in Finland. Almost everybody in a class holds a role, and the largest group is the one that laughs or is simply the audience.
Hawkins, Pepler and Craig, 2001	Social Development, 10(4), 512 to 527. 306 moments recorded across 125 hours of playground footage in Toronto. Another child stepped in 19 per cent of the time, and when they did it stopped within ten seconds 57 per cent of the time.
Chen and others, 2025	Trauma, Violence, and Abuse, 26(5), 938 to 954. 49 studies together. Teaching bystanders what to do changes what they do, and the programmes that work teach words rather than attitudes.





What I would actually say

Take one card between two. Write the words you would really use, not the ones that sound good. Nobody collects this.

THE MOMENT ON OUR CARD

MY FIRST WAY OUT

Circle the one you are using.

Do not laugh	Move it on	Say something after
--------------	------------	---------------------

The words I would use

MY SECOND WAY OUT

Circle the one you are using.

Do not laugh	Move it on	Say something after
--------------	------------	---------------------

The words I would use

MARKED BY SOMEBODY ELSE

Tick each one it passes.

Could they say it out loud?	Nobody put on trial?	Ends the audience?
-----------------------------	----------------------	--------------------

One change that would get it said





Eight moments

Cut along the dashed lines. One card between two, and they last as long as the paper does.

MOMENT 1

You hear a group laughing about somebody as they walk past, and one of them looks at you.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 2

A group is laughing about something a classmate said last week. They say it again when that person walks in.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 3

A friend tells you what somebody said about you when you were not there.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 4

Somebody keeps using a nickname for a classmate that started as a joke and is not one any more.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 5

The group you sit with has stopped saving a seat for one person, without anybody ever saying so.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 6

Somebody shows you something written about a classmate, and waits for you to laugh.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 7

A classmate answers a question wrong, and two people repeat it back in a silly voice.

Which way out, and what would you say?

MOMENT 8

Somebody you like is being funny about a person who is standing right there.

Which way out, and what would you say?

